Huberman x Raj Shamani — Content Notes

1. How to Engineer Your Cortisol for All-Day Energy & Focus

The core idea: Cortisol isn't just a "stress hormone" — it's an *energy-deploying* hormone. The goal is a specific pattern: **HIGH in the morning, LOW at night.**

Why it matters:

- High morning cortisol → more energy, focus, learning ability, stress resilience, easier sleep at night, and even a stronger immune system.
- Low nighttime cortisol → higher melatonin → deeper sleep.
- Cortisol and melatonin work on opposite cycles — boost one in the morning, and it naturally suppresses the other at night.

How to spike morning cortisol (do this in the first 30–60 min of waking):

- Go outside, look toward the sunlight (never stare directly — squint/blink to protect eyes). 5–10 minutes is enough.
- On cloudy days, this matters even more.
- Hydrate — water boosts cortisol.
- Caffeine — further boosts cortisol.
- Move your body if possible (walk, light exercise).

- Avoid: staying in bed scrolling your phone.
- No sunlight access? Use a 10,000 lux artificial light.

How to lower nighttime cortisol (last hour before bed):

- Dim the lights.
- No caffeine in the final 8 hours before sleep.
- Long exhale breathing (exhale longer than you inhale) — this slows heart rate and lowers cortisol.

"Bright mornings, dim nights — that's the whole game."

2. The Skill That Separates Elite Performers

The skill: Knowing how to turn your mind OFF, not just how to turn it on.

- Anyone can hit the gas pedal (hustle, grind, push). Few people know how to hit the brakes.
- Huberman's bet: given two equally hard-working people, the one who can **switch off and get deep sleep** will outperform the other over 5–10 years.
- "Turning off" doesn't mean stopping thoughts — it means stopping *thinking, planning, and doing*, and dropping into pure sensation (what your body feels, hears, senses right now).

Practical tool — The Left Column / Right Column exercise (from Navy SEAL Andy Stumpf):

- Once a month, draw two columns.

- **Left column:** things that worry you but you can't control (what people think, outcomes, etc.)
- **Right column:** things you can actually control (exercise, hydration, sleep, calling a friend)
- Whenever your mind drifts into the left column, consciously pull it back to the right column using a physical, present-moment action (take a sip of water, notice a sound, etc.)

"You don't need to be a machine 24/7 — you need an off switch."

3. The Exercise That Kills Anxiety in Minutes

The eye movement trick for falling asleep / calming the nervous system:

Steps (do with eyes closed):

1. Slowly move your eyes to one side, then the other.
2. Move your eyes counterclockwise, then clockwise.
3. Look gently toward the tip of your nose (don't cross your eyes).
4. Exhale.

Why it works: This disrupts your *proprioceptive circuits* (your brain's sense of where your body is in space). To fall asleep or calm down, your brain needs to "forget" where your body is. This eye movement short-circuits that system fast.

Bonus calming tool — cold exposure for anxiety/resilience:

- Cold shower spikes adrenaline for the first 20–30 seconds — that discomfort IS the training.

- Don't count time — instead notice the moment you want to get out, and push just a little past it ("one more wave"). This teaches your nervous system to ride out anxiety spikes in real life too.

"You can't always control anxiety, but you can train your body to ride the wave and come back down faster."

4. Why Yoga Nidra Beats Any Pill for Recovery

What it is: An ancient Indian practice (Huberman now also calls it "Non-Sleep Deep Rest" / NSDR) — lying down, slowing your breath, and shifting from *thinking/planning mode* into *pure sensation mode*.

Why it's powerful:

- No drug can safely take you out of "thinking mode" into pure rest the way this does — drugs that do this tend to cause a rough comeback/rebound.
- Studies show parts of the brain can enter deep sleep or even REM-like states during Yoga Nidra — meaning it's genuinely restorative, not just relaxing.
- It's trainable — the more you practice (10-30 min sessions, a few times a week), the better/faster you get at "switching off."

When to use it:

- First thing in the morning if you didn't sleep enough (recovers lost sleep).

- Mid-afternoon energy dip (2-3pm) instead of reaching for caffeine.
- To fall back asleep if you wake up at 2-4am.

Real example from the podcast: Raj Shamani said doing 10-20 min NSDR audios between back-to-back podcast recordings gave him more energy than coffee did.

"There's no pill that does what 20 minutes of stillness can do for your brain."

5. The 3-Phase Blueprint for Winning the Long Game

Phase 1 — Years 1-3: Go all-in.

- Full gas pedal. Learn aggressively, work hard, take risks.
- Rule: "Don't die" — meaning don't destroy your health or take reckless risks — but otherwise go all in.
- You need this phase to find your actual limits/edge.

Phase 2 — Years 4-6: Learn to dynamically regulate.

- This is where you start building balance instead of just pushing.
- Watch for burnout warning signs: hair falling out, skin issues, getting sick often, autoimmune flare-ups — signs that nighttime cortisol is staying too high for too long.
- You start learning your personal rhythm — how much real work you can sustainably do per day.

Phase 3 — Years 7+: You're a pro.

- You know your own signals — when you're stressed, when you need rest, when to disconnect.
- Now you can add "clutch states" — a term from high-performance training for repeatedly pushing through friction and effort (different from "flow," which only comes after mastery).
- This is also when you can guide/lead others effectively.

"Don't expect balance in year one. Go all in first — balance is a skill you earn later."

6. How to Build Unbreakable Resilience Through Friction

Core principle: Growth requires self-imposed friction — comfort alone doesn't build resilience, deliberately uncomfortable moments do.

Practical resilience-building tools:

1. **10-breath meditation before getting out of bed** — if you can't focus for 10 breaths, it's a signal you need to practice starting your day with control.
2. **Push your workouts harder, not easier** — in your working sets, actively try to make it harder (more focus, more intensity), not more comfortable.
3. **Widen your gaze when overwhelmed** — when stress feels like "tunnel vision," deliberately look around the whole room/space. This calms the nervous system and helps you see new options (used by pro athletes to see the whole court).

4. **Use memory of past wins** — recall a time you built something from nothing. Remind yourself: "I did that once, I can do it again."
5. **Do the slightly harder thing** — pick up the thing on the floor, take the harder path, on purpose, regularly.

Cold exposure principle again: The goal isn't to endure pain for its own sake — it's to teach your nervous system that discomfort passes, and that you're in control of your response to it.

"Resilience isn't a personality trait — it's a rep you build daily, like a muscle."

7. The Verb That Turns a Loser Mindset Into a Winner Mindset

The key insight: Both "winners" and "losers" have the same hard thoughts, doubts, and painful emotions. The difference isn't the feeling — it's the **action** taken with it.

"Losers take things that happen to them and ruminate on it, turning it into harm to themselves or others. Winners take the same things — good or bad — and transmute them into action that is generative, through hard work: journaling, self-talk, forcing better decisions."

It's a VERB, not an identity. You're not "a winner" or "a loser" — you're doing winner behaviours or loser behaviours in any given moment. That means it's always changeable, starting right now.

The rule in hard moments: Whatever you do — do NOT self-harm or harm others (through words, withdrawal, numbing

behaviours, etc.). If you can't do something generative yet, it's okay to just sit with the feeling and do nothing destructive for a few minutes. Then take one small action forward.

"You're not a winner or a loser — you're just someone who hasn't picked the winning action yet today.

Dr. Sahar Yousef x Raj Shamani — Teaching Notes

Simple breakdown of 7 key points, from a cognitive neuroscientist's podcast conversation.

1. Billionaire Brain vs. Yours

The core idea: Our belief system is what separates us from someone who is very successful. They have a drastically different way of thinking compared to a normal person; they have learnt to **shift their thought process.**

• It's not about IQ or having better ideas.

• The real difference is belief — they don't see limits.

• Where most people see a wall, they see a door they can build.

• Because of this belief, their brain actively looks for proof that supports it — so they spot opportunities others miss.

"Change the belief, and your brain starts noticing the opportunities that match it"

2. Building “Main Character Energy”

• **Write down a new identity on paper** — even if you don't fully believe it yet (“fake it till you make it”).

• **Simple 4-step formula:** Identity (“I'm the type of person who ___”) → Data (facts that back it up) → Payoff (what gets better) → Habit (the actual action).

• **Repeat it daily** — one-time journaling won't work; it needs repetition to reprogram belief.

“ Fake it on paper first, repetition makes it real.”

3. Why Your Phone Makes You Dumber (Even When It's Off)

• **Study:** people tested with phone in another room / in pocket / face-down on the desk — all phones were off.

• Just having it visible dropped attention and intelligence scores — **even dead.**

• **Why?** Your brain still associates it with memories, people, and dopamine, so part of your focus stays “**reserved**” for it.

• **Bonus:** people who keep phones visible during conversations are seen as less **trustworthy** and **less focused**.

“Out of sight, out of mind. Physically hide the phone during deep work or conversations.”

4. The Multitasking Myth

• **You have one brain**, one attention system — not two.

• “**Multitasking**” is just fast switching between tasks.

• Every switch cost **time and energy** — proven in a test where task-switching more than doubled completion time and caused more mistakes.

• **Bonus:** people who think they're great multitaskers test worse at it.

“*Do one thing at a time. "Multitasking" is just expensive task-switching.”*

5. Why You're Always Busy but Never Done

• **Constant notifications** hijack your brain's “alarm system,” pulling focus away before deep work even starts.

• This creates a **loop of activity** without real progress — busy, but not productive.

• **The fix isn't willpower** — it's environment. Remove distractions before starting, don't rely on discipline to resist them mid-task.

“Fix your environment, not your willpower — remove distractions before you start.”

6. Doom Scrolling vs. Bloom Scrolling

• **Short-form content** = junk food for the brain — feels good in the moment, but leaves you emptier (more anxious, more lonely).

• It doesn't fix the real need behind the scroll (usually stress or loneliness) — **so the craving comes right back.**

• **Long-form content** builds memory, focus, and empathy.

• **Fix:** don't quit scrolling completely — curate it. Follow accounts that teach you something ("bloom scrolling").

"Don't quit scrolling — curate it. Follow accounts/content that actually teach or nourish you."

7. The 3-Break Formula to Beat Burnout

• **Burnout isn't caused by stress** — it's caused by stress that never gets released ("completed").

- **Micro breaks** — a few minutes, every day.
- **Messo breaks** — 2–4 hours, every week.
- **Macro breaks** — half a day to a full day, every month.

• **Passive rest** (just lying around) often fails because the mind keeps worrying —

- **Active breaks** (a hobby, a new workout, cooking something new) work better because they fully occupy your attention.

"Schedule real breaks and make them engaging enough that you can't think about work."

Robert Greene x Raj Shamani

Podcast Notes

*1. **The Law of Desire**: Make Them Want What They Cannot Have*

The core idea: Human desire is contagious. We want what other people already want.

- If people see you're desired by others, they become interested too.
- Example: an empty restaurant vs. a packed, lively one — you're drawn to the one others already want.
- Being alone and undesired doesn't attract interest. Being surrounded by interest creates more interest.

How to apply it: Build genuine connections and a social circle. Let people naturally see that others value your time and attention — don't fake it, build it.

"People don't want what's available. They want what's already wanted."

***2. The Law of Absence**: Why Leaving Makes You More Desirable*

The core idea: If you're always around, people take you for granted. If you're occasionally absent, they notice and start wondering.

- Being present everywhere makes you replaceable — like everyone else.
- Being selectively absent creates curiosity: "Why isn't he here? What's he doing?"
- This applies to social media too — constant posting can make people numb to you, not more attached.

How to apply it: Don't show up to everything. Be intentional about where you spend your visible energy. Let your absence create a small gap people notice.

"Being everywhere makes you forgettable. Being selective makes you memorable."

3. The Law of Mystery*: Why Leaving Makes You More Desirable.*

The core idea: Real seduction/influence isn't about being present — it's about being on someone's mind when you're NOT there.

- Send "mixed signals" — appear one way, but reveal a surprising layer underneath (e.g., strong and masculine, but also artistic and soft).
- This contradiction makes people curious and keeps them thinking about you afterward.
- Being fully "readable" and predictable makes you forgettable.

How to apply it: Don't over-explain yourself. Let people discover layers of you over time instead of laying everything out immediately.

"If they can figure you out in one meeting, they'll forget you by tomorrow."

4. The Law of the Wound: Find What They Secretly Need.

The core idea: Everyone carries an emotional "wound" from childhood — something they never fully got (attention, validation, love) — and they're drawn to whoever can (consciously or not) fill that gap.

- People who are completely happy and "whole" are hard to seduce — there's nothing missing to fill.
- To connect deeply with someone, get them talking about their childhood. It reveals what they're missing without them realizing they're revealing it.
- This isn't manipulation by default — it can be genuine care. The skill itself is neutral; how you use it isn't.

How to apply it: Focus outward. Stop thinking about how you're coming across and start paying attention

to what the other person needs, values, or is missing.

"You don't fall for a person — you fall for whoever fills the gap you didn't know you had."

***5. The Law of the Chase**: Why Uncertainty Creates Obsession.*

The core idea: Certainty kills desire. Unpredictability creates addiction.

- The "coquette" archetype (hot and cold) is the most magnetic — always available = boring, always cold = uninteresting. The mix of both creates obsession.
- Neuroscience backs this: dopamine spikes hardest at around 50% odds — not from getting the reward, but from *not knowing* if you'll get it.
- This is the same mechanism social media feeds use to keep people scrolling — you never know if the next post will be great.

How to apply it: Don't be 100% predictable or 100% available. A little unpredictability (in a healthy, non-manipulative way) keeps interest alive.

"You're not addicted to the person — you're addicted to not knowing the answer."